



FALLING OUT: Troubles brew for Naidu as he fails to take a firm stand

would silence the proponents of a separate state. However, Naidu's gamble has backfired with Goud harnessing support from other party leaders. Also, in defiance of Naidu's warning to partymen not to endorse Telangana, some leaders have come out openly in favour of Goud and his cry for a separate state.

An embarrassed Naidu has cautioned all party leaders to refrain from speaking in public on the issue. A five-man committee to examine the demand, constituted in April, is yet to assess whether the party should

stick to the stand for *samayika* or united Andhra Pradesh or endorse the demand. "Taking a decision on the Telangana issue is not time-bound. We cannot take a call without considering the demands of the coastal and Rayalaseema regions and the prevailing ground realities there," says Naidu. His main worry is the fallout of a pro-Telangana stand in 175 constituencies in other parts of the state.

But Goud refuses to bite the bullet. He argues that if the TDP fails to finalise its stand, it could lose in the assembly polls, which are just 10 months away. This means that 119 seats are at stake after delimitation, an increase of 12. On the other hand, Naidu feels that there is no need for the TDP to take a hasty decision since its stakes for a

regional party are lesser than that for the Congress and BJP. Clearly, the debate for and against a separate Telangana state is bound to become shriller and raise further apprehensions of desertions in the party rank and file.

by Amarnath K. Menon

STATE OF DIVISION

The Telangana turmoil spells trouble for the TDP as its leaders begin speaking out against Naidu, demanding a separate state

The fissures are widening in the Telugu Desam Party (TDP) as the Telangana tangle morphs into a monolith and threatens to crack the party. At the helm of this new dissent is TDP Politburo member T. Devender Goud, who has publicly taken on party President N. Chandrababu Naidu. Goud, widely seen as the next in line after Naidu, is crying hoarse for a separate Telangana state. His vociferous demand is being seen as a direct confrontation with Naidu, who has been dragging his feet over the issue.

"It is high time we took a positive stand on the issue in deference to the wishes of the people of the region or face disastrous consequences," Goud told INDIA TODAY. While party spokesman and former minister T. Srinivas Yadav accuses Goud of trying to thrust his "personal agenda" on the party, pro-Telangana leaders in the TDP are

rallying behind Goud. "Those who want to enforce their own agenda might as well leave the party," says Yadav about Goud and his supporters.

Goud, who is also the party's deputy floor leader in the legislative assembly, contends that Yanamala Ramakrishnudu, former Speaker of the Assembly and a senior leader from the coastal region, "has encouraged Yadav to launch a personal attack on me because he is opposed to the division of Andhra Pradesh."

Goud's pronounced airing of the internal differences and the rebellious nature of a ginger group on the Telangana issue have come as a rude shock for Naidu, who hoped that the Telangana Rashtra Samithi's (TRS) defeat in the by-election



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T. DEVENDER GOUD, TDP POLITBURO MEMBER